



RISE & SHINE ABA LLC

Empowering children to reach their full potential

SESSION NOTE & DOCUMENTATION STANDARDS POLICY

Document v1.0 · Effective May 2026 · Annual Review Required

Governed by the laws of the State of New York

1. Purpose

Complete, accurate, and timely session documentation is a non-negotiable part of providing Applied Behavior Analysis services at Rise & Shine ABA. This Policy explains why documentation matters, what every session note must contain, when it must be submitted, and what happens when documentation does not meet these standards.

Complete documentation serves four purposes:

- **Client safety and clinical continuity.** The next clinician to see the child needs to understand what happened, what worked, and what didn't.
- **BACB ethical compliance.** The BACB Ethics Code for Behavior Analysts and the RBT Ethics Code both require accurate, contemporaneous documentation of all professional services.
- **Insurance billing and reimbursement.** Every dollar Rise & Shine ABA bills to a payer must be supported by a complete, signed session note. Incomplete notes are denied claims, and denied claims are lost revenue.
- **Legal record and audit defense.** Session notes are part of the official medical record. They protect the client, they protect you, and they protect the company in any audit, investigation, or legal proceeding.

2. Scope

This Policy applies to every Rise & Shine ABA team member who provides billable clinical services, including:

- Registered Behavior Technicians (RBTs)
- Board Certified Behavior Analysts (BCBAs) and BCaBAs
- Behavior Technicians
- Supervised Fieldwork Students
- Any other clinical staff providing direct or indirect services to clients

Compliance with this Policy is a condition of continued employment and continued client assignment.

3. Required Elements of a Compliant Session Note

Every session note must contain **all of the following elements** before it is considered complete:

- **Client name and client ID number** (matching the assigned chart in Artemis)
- **Date of service**
- **Exact session start time and exact session end time** (to the minute — no rounding)
- **Total session duration** (must equal end time minus start time)
- **Service location** (in-home, clinic, school, telehealth, or community setting)
- **CPT code billed** (e.g., 97153 for direct treatment by RBT, 97155 for protocol modification by BCBA, 97156 for parent training, 97151 for assessment)
- **Specific goals and objectives addressed during the session** (must be linked to the current treatment plan — generic goals are not acceptable)
- **Interventions and ABA procedures used** (e.g., discrete trial training, natural environment teaching, prompting strategies, reinforcement schedules)
- **Client's response to interventions** — with both quantitative data (trial-by-trial percentages, frequency counts, duration) and qualitative observations
- **Behavioral incidents that occurred during the session** (antecedent, behavior, consequence — even if no formal incident report was filed)
- **Plan for next session** (targeted goals, any modifications based on today's session)
- **RBT signature with credentials** (electronic signature in Artemis)
- **Parent or guardian signature** confirming the session occurred — required for every session except where waived in writing for telehealth
- **Supervising BCBA review and signature** where required by payer or clinical protocol

4. Submission Timeline

The 24-Hour Rule

Every session note must be entered, signed, and submitted in Artemis within 24 hours of the session end time. This is a hard deadline. Notes submitted after 24 hours are considered late and may be non-billable, which means the company cannot collect revenue for that session and cannot continue to assign the unsupported work.

"Submitted" means the note is fully entered in Artemis with all required signatures (RBT, parent/guardian, and BCBA where applicable). A draft saved but not signed is not submitted.

This 24-hour rule exists because:

- Most payers, including Medicaid, require contemporaneous documentation. Late notes can be retroactively denied even if they are otherwise complete.

- Memory accuracy degrades quickly. A note written days later is less accurate, less specific, and easier to challenge in audit.
- Billing cycles are time-sensitive. Late notes hold up the entire claims process for the company.

5. Quality Standards

Every session note must meet the following quality standards:

Objective and Behavioral

Notes must describe what was observed in objective, behavioral terms. Avoid:

- **Subjective opinions** (e.g., "client was frustrated," "client had a bad day")
- **Generic descriptions** (e.g., "client did well," "good session")
- **Diagnostic language outside your scope** (RBTs do not diagnose; BCBAs use diagnostic language only as authorized by the treatment plan)

Instead, describe observable behavior: "Client engaged in 7 instances of vocal protest (saying 'no') during the demand task between 2:15 PM and 2:30 PM. Following implementation of the planned escape extinction procedure, vocal protest decreased to 2 instances during the 2:30–2:45 PM block."

Specific and Measurable

Notes must include data. "Client made progress" is not documentation — "Client mastered 3 of 4 targeted programs at 90% accuracy across 2 consecutive sessions" is documentation.

Stored Only in Approved Systems

All session notes and any PHI must be stored only in approved Rise & Shine ABA systems — currently Artemis (clinical EHR) and the Rise & Shine HRM. PHI must never be:

- Saved on personal devices
- Sent through personal email or text
- Stored in personal cloud accounts (Google Drive, iCloud, Dropbox)
- Photographed or screenshotted
- Discussed in non-secure communication channels

6. Top 10 Documentation Errors That Cause Claim Denials

These are the most common reasons claims are denied or recouped after audit. Avoid all of them.

1. **Vague language** describing the session — "client did well," "good day," or "made progress" without measurable data.
2. **Rounded times** instead of exact start and end times — for example, listing "2:00–4:00 PM" when the actual session was 2:07–3:52 PM.
3. **Missing parent or guardian signature** confirming the session occurred.
4. **Late submission** past the 24-hour window.

5. **Generic goals copy-pasted** from the treatment plan without describing what was specifically targeted in the session.
6. **Wrong or missing CPT code** for the type of service delivered.
7. **Subjective opinions** instead of behavioral observations — "client was being difficult," "client was happy."
8. **No measurable client response** — interventions described without any data on how the client responded.
9. **Time on the timesheet does not match** the session note duration. Auditors look for this first.
10. **Notes saved or shared outside approved systems** — personal email, personal devices, text messages, or any non-Artemis location.

7. Consequences of Non-Compliance

Failure to meet these documentation standards is treated as a performance and compliance issue. The company will follow a tiered approach:

1. **First offense:** Verbal warning from supervising BCBA or Director of Operations, documented in the personnel file. Coaching on the specific deficiency.
2. **Second offense:** Written warning, documented in the personnel file, with required completion of a documentation refresher training.
3. **Continued non-compliance:** Suspension of new client assignments. Existing assignments may also be reassigned to ensure continuity of care for clients.
4. **Productivity bonuses:** Any productivity bonus, incentive pay, or compliance-tied compensation will be forfeited for the period in which non-compliance occurred.
5. **Insurance billing:** Sessions without complete, timely documentation may not be billed to insurance, which may impact the company's ability to continue assigning paid work.
6. **Chronic non-compliance:** May result in termination of employment, in accordance with at-will employment and applicable progressive discipline procedures.

Wage Protection Notice

Rise & Shine ABA will pay all wages owed for time actually worked in accordance with applicable federal and New York State wage and hour law, regardless of documentation status. The consequences listed above relate to disciplinary action, future client assignments, and incentive compensation — they do not affect wages already earned for hours worked.

8. Audit & Review

To support compliance and continuous improvement:

- **Weekly:** Each supervising BCBA reviews all session notes from their assigned RBTs from the prior week. Deficiencies are addressed in writing within 5 business days.
- **Monthly:** The Director of Operations and Compliance Officer review aggregate compliance reports — submission timeliness, signature completeness, and audit-flagged notes — and identify any RBTs or cases needing intervention.
- **Quarterly:** Documentation compliance is included in each RBT's quarterly performance scorecard.
- **Annually:** This Policy is reviewed and updated as needed based on changes in payer requirements, BACB standards, and New York law.

Questions about this Policy should be directed to the Director of Operations or the Compliance Officer.

Acknowledgment of this Policy is captured on the Documentation & Time Recording Acknowledgment Form, which must be signed at hire and re-acknowledged annually.